

A woman with long, wavy brown hair and a nose ring is looking upwards and to the left. She is wearing a light-colored, sleeveless top. The background features a large, ornate building with blue and white tiled roofs and brick pillars, set against a warm, orange-hued sunset sky. The ocean is visible in the distance.

✿ THE FREE ONE-DAY GUIDE · SUMMER EDITION

Málaga *in a day*

Picasso's city, a Moorish fortress built over a Roman theatre, and sardines grilled on a boat full of sand. Here is exactly how I'd spend one summer day in it — hour by hour, with the prices, the timings and the places I'd actually send a friend to.

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HOURLY BY HOURLY

The perfect *day*

9:00

Alcazaba, right when it opens

The Moorish fortress-palace, 11th century. Go first thing: by noon the stone is an oven. **€7**, or **€10** combined with Gibralfaro castle — and free on Sunday afternoons from 2pm.

10:30

The Roman theatre at its feet

1st century, and you walk right through it — the orchestra still has its original marble floor. **Free**, Tue–Sat 10–18h, Sun 10–16h. Closed Mondays.

11:30

The cathedral they never finished

La Manquita, "the one-armed lady" — only one of its two bell towers was ever built. Sit in the Plaza del Obispo with its Baroque fountain and look up.

12:30

Mercado de Atarazanas

The market under the stained-glass window. Mon–Sat 8–14h, closed Sundays. Eat standing at one of its bars — that's the point.

14:00

Espetos on La Malagueta

Sardines threaded on canes and grilled over a wood fire in an old boat filled with sand. Sit where you can see the fire.

16:00

Siesta. Non-negotiable

Nothing opens, nobody moves. Stay on the beach under a parasol until the sun stops trying to kill you.

18:30

Mirador de Gibralfaro

130m above the sea, the whole bay at your feet — the port, the bullring, the cathedral. **Free** if you only go to the viewpoint.

20:30

Sunset at Los Baños del Carmen

A 1918 seaside bathhouse with eucalyptus trees over the water. Locals go, tour groups don't. Stay for dinner if you can.



WHAT TO ORDER

Eat like a *malagueña*

Espeto de sardinas

es-PEH-to deh sar-DEE-nas

Six sardines on a cane, salted and grilled over olive wood in a sand-filled boat. Eat them with your fingers, skin and all.

Where: Chiringuito Picasso, Paseo Marítimo Pablo Ruiz Picasso

Ensalada malagueña

en-sa-LA-da ma-la-GHE-nya

Orange, salt cod, potato, olives and onion. Sounds strange, works perfectly, and it's the coldest thing you'll eat all day.

Where: any old tavern in the centre

Ajoblanco

a-ho-BLAN-ko

Chilled almond and garlic soup with grapes. Gazpacho's older, paler, better cousin — and it only exists in summer.

Where: Mercado de Atarazanas bars

Vino dulce de Málaga

VEE-no DOOL-theh

Sweet Muscatel wine, served small and cold, poured from the barrel in century-old bars. One glass, not three.

Where: Antigua Casa de Guardia, Alameda Principal



The espetero boat: sand, olive wood and six sardines per cane. 🌿

Two rules: never order espetos in a month with an "R" in it — from May to August the sardine is at its fattest, and that's the whole secret. And never order sangría; ask for a *tinto de verano*, which is what everyone around you is drinking.



KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

Local *survival kit*

1 Everything is walkable

The old town is small: cathedral to Alcazaba is five minutes, market to beach is fifteen. You won't need a taxi all day — only for Gibralfaro, which is a steep climb in August.

2 Mondays close half the city

The Roman theatre and most museums shut on Mondays. If that's your only day, swap them for the market, the beach and Gibralfaro.

3 Book the Alcazaba, skip the queue

Buy the combined ticket online. And go up to Gibralfaro on foot only if it's early — otherwise take bus 35 from the Alameda.

4 2 to 5pm doesn't exist

Shops close, streets empty. Don't plan anything. This is what the beach and the long lunch are for.

5 If it rains — it won't, but if

Picasso was born here, and both the Museo Picasso and his birthplace on Plaza de la Merced are ten minutes from the cathedral. Perfect wet-morning plan.

6 La Malagueta vs Pedregalejo

La Malagueta is the city beach, five minutes from the centre. For the old fishermen's chiringuitos, take the bus east to Pedregalejo or El Palo.

✿ **Lucy's golden rule:** plan the morning, never the afternoon. In August the city decides what you do between two and six, not you.

Say it like a *local*

Málaga

MA-la-ga

Stress the first syllable, not the second. Everyone gets this wrong.

Espeto

es-PEH-to

The cane the sardines are grilled on — and, by extension, the dish itself.

Chiringuito

chee-reen-GHEE-to

A beach bar with its feet in the sand. The word is half the holiday.

Boquerón

bo-keh-RON

An anchovy — and also what people from Málaga call themselves.

Una cañita

OO-na ka-NYEE-ta

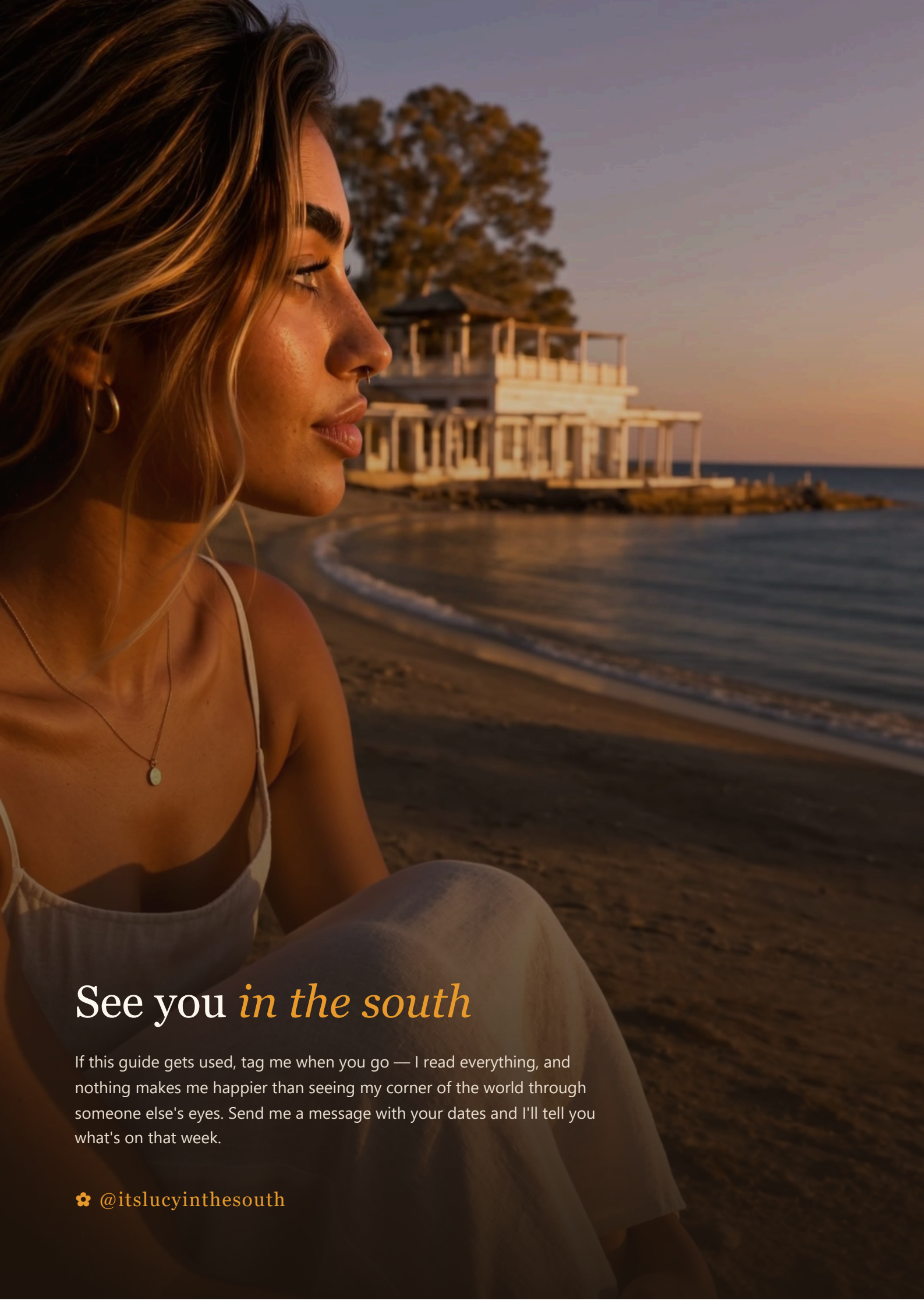
A small, very cold draft beer. The diminutive means you'll have several.

Sobremesa

so-breh-MEH-sa

The hour of talk after the plates are empty. No English word for it, because it isn't a habit — it's the point of lunch.

If you have a second day 🌸 Take the train to **El Caminito del Rey**, a walkway pinned to the wall of a gorge an hour north — book weeks ahead, it sells out. Or go east to **Nerja and Frigiliana**, a white village stacked up a hillside. If you'd rather not leave the city: the **Museo Picasso**, the rooftop of the cathedral, and the sunset from the **Muelle Uno** promenade.



See you *in the south*

If this guide gets used, tag me when you go — I read everything, and nothing makes me happier than seeing my corner of the world through someone else's eyes. Send me a message with your dates and I'll tell you what's on that week.

✿ @itslucyinthelouth